them is far more significant than what divides them. This is not illogical, because in her recent work, Dr Pippa Virdee has shown how Punjab—which had uniquely achieved a hybridity of communal coexistence between Muslims, Hindus and Sikhs on the basis of a shared inheritance of *Punjabiyat* carefully nurtured over centuries past—saw in the Partition of 1947 its ethnic history submerged within respective national and religious identity(s) like no other state in the subcontinent. She has persuasively demonstrated how none paid the price of Partition like the pluralistic, pre-Partition Punjab.[3] This idea of *Punjabiyat* was moulded by none other than Maharajah Ranjit Singh, who held sway over Punjab from 1792 until his death in 1839, covering an area which is roughly the size of modern-day Pakistan. This is highlighted by the foremost historian Fakir S. Aijazuddin, who has recently made it clear how, 'Ranjit Singh's uniqueness lay in giving Punjabiyat a political identity, in welding the Punjab nation into a sovereign state', in circumstances where Punjab, through a thousand years of conquest, had actually belonged 'never to itself'[4] but to others. Punjabis therefore do not recognize the identity politics of Gujarat in present-day India, as the concept is alien to them.

Bhagat Singh can help resurrect the importance of Punjabiyat in a collective culture shared by the peoples of both West Punjab (in Pakistan) and East Punjab (in India) just as Maharajah Ranjit Singh did in times long since forgotten. Those who remember Ranjit Singh do so not only with a fondness for what stood as the high-point of Punjab's multicultural identity, but also as an acknowledgement and a longing for Punjab's one-time greatness. As Aijazuddin reminds us, 'Few of the post-Mughal regional courts had the power or the military might and discipline to take on armies of the East India Company. But one that did with great success was Ranjit Singh's Sikh Empire.'[5]

In the same way, those who today recall what Bhagat Singh stood for do so with no less admiration for the ultimate ideals of Punjabiyat—namely, the pluralism, diversity, broad-mindedness and tolerance of its people. It is Punjabiyat that has ultimately become the basis of the quest for a better and a more just future. A false dividing border—all too arbitrarily imposed after